

Dear Mama,

Today Johnson announced his plan for the war - and I sit here shaking in my boots! At a critical time in the war, when the VC/NVA are poised for the second offensive, Johnson decides not to bomb in the North. I am really getting shaky, watching the politicians setting policies on war, when they have no idea what is going on. B. Kennedy, as I said in my last letter is out of his head (though I had said in an earlier letter I would like to see Kennedy and Rocky fight it out) LBJ is being commended for what was an obvious political move intended to strengthen his party - not win the war (or bring peace.). McCarthy has little understanding of our commitment here and the necessity for that commitment. These views are of course my views.

Soon Charlie will begin his second offensive - he started last night with a rocket attack. Things are going to get worse. Charlie's success in this next offensive is directly correlated with the amount of supplies he can get to support his attack. Especially rockets. Who makes rockets? the Chinese. How do they send them down? By train, through N. Vietnam. So at the most crucial time, when the halting of supplies is most essential to us - LBJ decides to halt bombing in the North. The question arises, why did he decide to do this now. Because the primaries are coming up and the democrats are in a hurt. It takes drama to stop a trend like the one that is working against the Democratic party.

One thing that is happening because of the overstress on the political decision-making is that our senators and rep's are beginning to feel that because they made a few tours of Vietnam they are qualified experts on Vietnam. That is poppycock. Yet they are the ones who make the decisions. Everyone has a theory about how the war should be run - but most plans

are based on inaccuracies and mis understanding. Example - UPI reports a group of citizens who want the troops to use close in protection of populated areas. B. Kennedy says don't go on search and destroy missions. That is exactly what Charlie wants us to do. Sit back, while he builds up his supplies and puts the troops in position to attack. The French tried that - and it didn't work. It was the opposite strategy that kept the VC/NVA from attacking soon after TET as we had expected. I don't mind being over if I am fighting a war with a sane plan - but this sitting back and letting Charlie build up to wipe us out is for the birds.

This is a age old problem - deciding who should run the war - the politicians or the military. I think it is the politicians who must decide about whether to fight the war - and then let the military fight it. politicians are not aware of all the things we are up against. I don't like being sacrificed in a politicians war. I firmly believe we belong over here - but not to pussyfoot, to fight the war as it should be fought. I do not advise the use of nuclear weapons - but bombing of the north I do recommend. Believe me it is very different when you are sitting over here knowing what is happening - than sitting in the states guessing.

Deescalation is basically a good goal - but not when the enemy is at your doorstep, ready to attack. That is unrealistic. B.K. is the same way - full of good ideas - unrealistic - but good.

It is not all pessimistic - but the situation is definitely very serious - and we don't kid ourselves about that.

Things here real busy - found out today the VC have names of my people (and me) and our vehicle numbers - real fine. Got this from

interrogations - along with other good poop.

Buildings all most finished. It is so hot - I don't work real fast. spend some time in Northwe. We are working up around the Cambodian border now. I have Three teams up there.

Our ARVN counterparts are working out pretty well. For the most part they are on the ball. Vietnamese intelligence training is better, at least in theory than ours. Some problems in methods. For example they like to use torture and force. I have found that for the most part these are unnecessary - an intelligent interrogator can out-think his prisoner - esp since most have little education..

Rick due out here in about ten days. His orders have been slow but I think things are moving along now.

Met a good friend from OCS last week - joining our unit as a platoon leader. The first one from our class who is not intelligence. He said others are on their way - sorry about that GI!!!

Letter from Susie bringing me up to date on the family - she did okay on grades - better than me on my first year - glad to know someone had trouble with French like I did!

Also letter from Gram - and Diane - so I have that side of the family covered. Looking forward to reports of the Florida trips.

Peace to all and to all a good night - time for my refreshing cool shower. It is a bit better now, because it is so hot the water is warmer. Apologies for spelling ect - I ran through this letter. So more ideas to hash over.

Love to all the Wrights and Turners,

long O Lt. Stephen B. Wright
(House girls call me Mom Be (bear) which means small mouth!